

Local-Self Governance

Governor

Local Self-Governance

Panchayati Raj

- ❖ The Panchayati Raj System is the first tier or level of democratic government.
- ❖ The term Panchayati Raj in India signifies the system of rural local self-government. It was constitutionalized through the 73rd Constitutional Amendment Act of 1992.
- ❖ The development of the village was the immediate problem faced by our country after independence. Hence the Community Development Programme was launched in 1952 with a view to carrying out the integral rural development work.
- ❖ Rajasthan was the first state to set up Panchayati Raj System in 1959 followed by Andhra Pradesh.

Main Provisions of 73rd Amendment Act

- ❖ This act has added a new Part-IX to the Constitution of India.
- ❖ It is entitled as 'The Panchayats' & consists of provisions from Articles 243(A) to 243 (O). In addition, the act has also added a new Eleventh Schedule to the Constitution. It contains 29 functional items of the Panchayats.
- ❖ Fixing tenure of five years for Panchayats at all levels & holding fresh elections within six months in the event of super session of any Panchayat.
- ❖ Reservation of 1/3 seats (both members & chairpersons) for women in Panchayats at all the levels.
- ❖ The Act provides for a three-tier system of the Panchayati Raj in the states namely:
 - (i) Gram Panchayat at the Village level.
 - (ii) Panchayat Samiti at the Block level.
 - (iii) Zila Parishad at the District level.

Compulsory Provisions for Panchayati Raj Institutions

1. Organisation of Gram Sabha in a village or group of villages.
2. Establishment of Panchayats at the village, intermediate & district levels.

3. 21 years to be the minimum age for contesting elections to Panchayats.
4. Reservation of seats (both members & chairpersons) for SCs & STs in Panchayats at all the three levels.
5. Reservation of one-third seats (both members & chairpersons) for women in Panchayats at all the three levels.
6. Fixing tenure of five years for Panchayats at all levels & holding fresh elections within six months in the event of supersession of any Panchayat.
7. Establishment of a State Election Commission for conducting elections to the Panchayats.
8. Constitution of a State Finance Commission after every five years to review the financial position of the panchayats.

Organisational Structure

(i) Gram Panchayat at the Village level

The members of the Gram Panchayat are elected by the Gram Sabha. The Pradhans (Presidents) of the Gram Sabha are the ex-officio members of the Gram Panchayat.

Note: Gram Sabha means a body consisting of persons registered in the electoral roles relating to a village comprised within the area of Panchayat at the village level.

(ii) Panchayat Samiti at the Block level

The Panchayat Samiti has many Gram Panchayats under it. All the Presidents of the Panchayats within the Block are the ex officio members of the 'Panchayat Samitis'.

(iii) Zila Parishad at the District level

- ❖ Zila Parishad is an apex body under the Panchayati Raj. It co-ordinates the activities of the various Panchayat Samitis.
- ❖ Zila Parishad actually makes developmental plans at the district level.
- ❖ With the help of Panchayat Samitis, it also regulates the money distribution among all the Gram Panchayats.